

Evolution and Compatibility

Compatibility with previous versions of Windows is a very important aspect of Windows. Over time Windows has added and removed features, but has always tried to keep compatibility wherever possible and feasible. For instance, 32-bit versions of Windows 10 still support applications developed for 16bit versions of Windows and DOS!

64-bit versions of Windows meanwhile haven't been able to support 16-bit applications since as far back as XP. If those applications (written for the Windows 3.1 era) are compiled into a 32-bit version, they will still run on Windows 10!

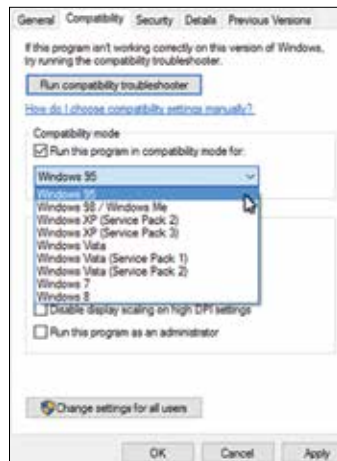
The main reason for this is that Windows has become quite good at lying about its version number to suit the app running on it. For a long time Windows has had the capability of representing itself as an older version for compatibility with old applications. Windows mostly tried to be good at detecting if an application is written for a previous version of Windows, and then running it in compatibility mode.

If you encounter an app that worked on a previous version of Windows, but no longer works in the latest release, you can right click it and select compatibility settings. This includes not only lying about the Windows version to trick the application into thinking it is running on a compatible version of Windows, but also reducing the colour mode and resolution to make it work.

Since Windows already has a framework in place to do behave like older versions of Windows and lie about its version number to run older apps, does it really matter what the correct number is? Might as well go for something that makes more sense.



A 32bit version of Ski free, a Windows 3.1 game running on Windows 10 64bit.



You can right click and set compatibility settings for any application.